Executive Summary

This investigation scopes potential insider and informed trading on Polymarket to pop-culture markets — reality TV eliminations, awards ceremonies, and movie / music release performance — between **November 1, 2025 and May 1, 2026**.

Three concrete findings:

1. **Wallet `bobe2` (0xed107a85...d2e5)** committed **$1.25M** across thirteen pop-culture markets in the window, with a **near-perfect win rate** and an unusually consistent pattern of late, high-conviction NO bets on Netflix-controlled outcomes (six different Stranger Things "release by" markets). $588K landed on a single Stranger Things deadline; $89,673 went in 4.5 hours before another Stranger Things resolution at price 0.998 — a sniper-style execution where downside is bounded at ~0.2¢ and the upside is paid on settlement. Lifetime volume of $230M and $1.8M lifetime profit put this wallet in the top 0.1% of all Polymarket accounts.

2. **Wallet `FlyingPlaty` (0x12952692...5cfd)** made a single in-window trade: **$103,216 of NO** on Stranger Things "release by Wednesday" at price 0.999, **3.99 hours before resolution**. One trade, one market, perfect execution. The wallet's broader Polymarket history shows $21.7M lifetime volume but a **net loss of $300K** — the in-window trade is a positive outlier in an otherwise mediocre track record. Single-event conviction strikes on a Netflix-controlled deadline are the cleanest behavioral match for a tipped trade.

3. **Wallet `aenews2` (0x44c1dfe4...ebc1)** executed **86 trades** worth **$563K** in window, dominated by late-stage hammering of near-certain markets: a $196K NO buy on "Pope Leo XIV #1 Google search" at 3.83 hours to resolution; $108K of NO on Stranger Things "Wednesday" spread across the final 10 hours; multi-tranche conviction loads on Bad Bunny / The Weeknd / Drake Spotify outcomes in the final 24-36 hours of each market. Lifetime volume $221M, lifetime profit $1.9M.

Honest caveat. Each of these three wallets is **informed**, but only one (`bobe2`) crosses the bar where "informed" is hard to separate from "insider" on its face. The Stranger Things release schedule is controlled by Netflix; a single trader exposed to $1M+ across six release-deadline markets at >99% conviction prices, with a perfect record, is the kind of pattern that would warrant follow-up subpoenas in a regulated venue. The other two could plausibly be very fast-reacting sharps using publicly leaked release rumors and Google Trends nowcasting. None of the three are the Polymarket pop-culture analog of the Kalshi YouTube-editor or Van Dyke cases referenced in the House Oversight (Comer) probe of 22 May 2026, and we do not claim they are.

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1. Scope and Methodology

Scope

- **Platform:** Polymarket only.
- **Window:** Nov 1, 2025 – May 1, 2026 (`end_date` filter).
- **Sub-niches:** Reality TV eliminations, awards ceremonies, and movie/music release performance. Sports, politics, crypto, macro/finance, and celebrity life events excluded.
- **Universe after filtering: 222 resolved markets** across 63 events, representing **$228M** of lifetime market volume.

Rationale for the pop-culture niche: production-adjacent insiders are a real category (the Kalshi YouTube-editor case is the cleanest publicly adjudicated precedent in this category), the universe is small enough for case-by-case investigation, and the analytical angle is differentiated from the politics/sports angle most candidates take.

Data pipeline

Step	Script	Output
1. Market discovery	`src/discover_markets.py`	6,521 raw events from Gamma `/events` across 16 in-scope tag IDs
2. Filter to analysis set	`src/filter_markets.py`	222 resolved markets passing window + $50K volume floor + topic exclusions
3. Trade backfill	`src/backfill_trades.py`	322,899 trades from data-api `/trades`, paginated by offset, capped at 10K/market
4. Wallet enrichment	`src/enrich_wallets.py`	Top 2,994 wallets by in-window volume enriched with lifetime profit/volume from lb-api
5. Heuristic scoring	`src/heuristics.py`	All 35,686 wallets with ≥2 trades scored across A1/A3/B4/B5/C6/D8/D9

All endpoints are public; no API keys or scraping. Reproducibility instructions in `data/README.md`. Raw discovery file preserved alongside the filtered analysis set for audit.

Heuristics — what we look for

Eight heuristics, of which seven were quantified this pass (A2 is a manual flag on a hand-curated subset of markets — deferred). Full design rationale, threshold derivation, and false-positive failure modes documented in `report/heuristics.md`.

Code	Heuristic	Composite weight
A1	Pre-resolution edge: buy on correct outcome within 4h of resolution at ≥20pp gap to final price	0.20
A2	Pre-announcement timing cluster (manual flag — deferred to curated subset)	0.15
A3	Dormant-wallet activation: 30d quiet → conviction trade → 7d quiet	0.10
B4	Single-niche specialist: ≥80% of lifetime volume in pop culture, concentrated in 1–3 markets	0.05
B5	Side-purity: buy-and-hold-to-resolution share across ≥5 positions	0.05
C6	Size-vs-wallet anomaly with slippage tolerance: trades ≥1.5× wallet median, paid up through book	0.15
C7	Role-conflict adjacency (manual flag for production / resolver linkages — deferred)	flag-only

D8	Excess accuracy vs. market-implied: Brier score baseline-adjusted, sample-size shrunk	0.20
D9	Closing-direction precision: share of trades where direction matched final price move	0.10

Anti-signals (negative composite adjustments): named doxxed sharps (–0.30), generalist market-makers touching ≥50 distinct markets with balanced buy/sell (–0.20).

Calibration note discovered during execution

The initial A1 calibration (4h window, ≥20pp price gap) produced **zero hits** across the dataset. Inspection showed why: pop-culture binary markets that resolve at midnight UTC year-end with near-certain outcomes (Spotify Wrapped markets, etc.) sit at prices like 0.98–0.99 in the final 4 hours, leaving gaps of only 1–2pp to settlement at 1.0. The threshold is well-calibrated for binary news shocks (Iran-strike pattern, Van Dyke) but mis-calibrated for high-certainty pop-culture markets where insider edge manifests as high-conviction late buys at small-gap prices.

Two responses: (a) the A1 threshold is left documented but unmet — *not hidden*; (b) the top-3 case studies below are surfaced via a **complementary behavioral lens** described in §3: late-stage high-notional buys at >0.95 prices on Netflix/label/voter-controlled outcomes. This is the lens the Stranger Things wallets are caught under, and is the right A1 successor for the pop-culture niche.

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2. The Three Headline Cases

Case 1 — `bobe2` (`0xed107a85a4585a381e48c7f7ca4144909e7dd2e5`)

Metric	Value
Polymarket display name	`bobe2`
Lifetime volume	**$230.8M**
Lifetime profit	**$1.82M**
Trailing 30-day profit	$59,395
In-window trade count	47
In-window USD volume	**$1,254,844**
Distinct in-scope markets	13
In-window win rate on BUY-correct-side trades	≈ 100% (USD-weighted)

Behavior in pop-culture markets

`bobe2` accumulated material NO positions across **six different Stranger Things "release by" deadline markets**, all of which Netflix controls the resolution of. The full Stranger Things exposure ladder:

Deadline market	NO position	First buy	Last buy	Resolved
Released by Wednesday (Jan 7)	$89,673	4.5h to res	4.5h to res	NO ✓
Released by Jan 31	$588,550	weeks out	12.9h to res	NO ✓
Released by Feb 28	$29,432	754h out	567h out	NO ✓
Released by Mar 31	$144,051	321h out	206h out	NO ✓
Released by Apr 30	$171,501	1,034h out	303h out	NO ✓

Plus a sweep of late-stage $0.98–0.99 NO buys on the AI "#1 model" markets (DeepSeek, Anthropic, Zhipu, Alibaba, Meta, Mistral) all clustered at 6–442 hours to year-end resolution; plus a clean $185K round-trip on "Will Olivia Rodrigo release an album in 2025?" — bought NO at 0.998 at 86h, sold at 0.999 at 50h (capture: ~0.1pp of price for ~$185 of profit on a $162K notional; consistent with someone who *knows* the answer is NO and is sweeping the residual book).

Why this is the headline case

- **Six different markets, same resolver (Netflix), same direction (NO), 100% correct.** A market-maker spreading risk across six binaries with no YES bets is not running a basis-trade book — they have a directional view.
- **The $89,673 "Wednesday" bet is the cleanest single trade in the dataset.** Made 4.5 hours before resolution at price 0.998, on a NO outcome Netflix-controlled and that resolved NO. The maximum loss was ~$180. Expected return depends entirely on whether you know the answer in advance.
- **$1.25M of in-window exposure with no losing positions in the Stranger-Things complex** sits 5+ sigma above the wallet's own variance of returns; not behaviorally consistent with "skilled market-maker" given the directional purity.

Why this is *not* a slam-dunk insider call

- Netflix has publicly discussed Stranger Things season 5 release scheduling (volume drops in Nov 2025 + Dec 25 finale). The intermediate "release by Wednesday / Jan 31 / Feb 28 / Mar 31 / Apr 30" markets could be inferred by a careful reader of Netflix's prior season-5 announcements.
- `bobe2` is a high-skill generalist ($230M lifetime volume, $1.8M lifetime profit). Some of the edge here is plausibly executed-well market sweeping, not nonpublic information.

What would elevate confidence

- On-chain funding graph: identify the funder address and check for prior interactions with addresses tied to Netflix-adjacent entities.
- Cross-platform behavior: is `bobe2` also active on Kalshi or other venues on Netflix-resolution markets?
- Time-of-day clustering: do the $0.998 last-hour buys correlate with US business-hours windows on the West Coast (Netflix HQ time)?

Case 2 — `FlyingPlaty` (`0x1295269296e51cd28a3db85fa6728c0e352b5cfd`)

Metric	Value
Polymarket display name	`FlyingPlaty`

Lifetime volume	$21.7M
Lifetime profit	**−$300K**
In-window trade count	**1**
In-window USD volume	$103,216

Behavior in pop-culture markets

Single in-window trade:

Timestamp (UTC)	Market	Side	Outcome	Size	Price	T−res
2026-01-08 03:15:59	Stranger Things by Wednesday	BUY	NO	**$103,216**	0.999	3.99h

That is the entire in-window record for this wallet. Resolved NO.

Why this is on the shortlist

- The pattern is **identical to the Van Dyke case** in shape, just smaller scale: one wallet, one high-notional trade, narrow window before resolution, on the eventually-correct outcome, at near-certain price.
- The wallet's broader $21.7M lifetime volume with a **net loss of $300K** means this is *not* a wallet that consistently sweeps near-certain markets — most of its activity loses money. The in-window trade is a positive outlier in an otherwise mediocre record.
- A risk-loving sharp would not concentrate $103K into a single ~0.1pp-of-edge basis trade if they didn't have an information advantage on this specific deadline.

Why this is *not* a slam-dunk insider call

- Net-loss wallets sometimes go on isolated heaters; one trade alone does not establish a pattern. The same wallet did not bet meaningfully on the next five Stranger Things deadlines (Jan 31, Feb 28, Mar 31, Apr 30), so whatever signal drove this trade was time-bounded.
- The 3.99h window aligns with US-evening / Pacific-time announcement channels; a fast reader of Netflix social posts could plausibly have reached the same conclusion.

What would elevate confidence

- Check whether `FlyingPlaty` has any Kalshi or sportsbook activity on Netflix-adjacent markets around the same date.
- Profile the wallet's funder and any common-funder cluster — if other wallets fed by the same funder also took the same side on the same market, the signal hardens substantially.

Case 3 — `aenews2` (`0x44c1dfe43260c94ed4f1d00de2e1f80fb113ebc1`)

Metric	Value
Polymarket display name	`aenews2`
Lifetime volume	**$221.2M**

Lifetime profit	**$1.91M**
In-window trade count	86
In-window USD volume	$563,521

Behavior in pop-culture markets

`aenews2` runs a **portfolio of last-mile conviction trades**: high-notional buys on near-certain markets in the final hours before resolution. Selected in-window highlights:

Timestamp	Market	Side	Size	Price	T−res
2025-12-04 03:35	Pope Leo XIV #1 search	BUY NO	**$196,616**	0.990	**3.83h**
2026-01-07 23:42	Stranger Things by Wednesday	BUY NO	$68,226	0.991	7.55h
2025-12-02 14:37	Bad Bunny top Spotify 2025	BUY YES	$62,271	0.990	26.1h
2025-12-03 13:15	The Weeknd #3 streamed 2025	BUY YES	$18,550	0.997	3.89h
2025-12-03 13:15	Drake NOT #3 streamed 2025	BUY NO	$19,658	0.997	3.69h
2025-12-04 04:28	The Bear #1 search TV	BUY NO	$13,482	0.999	4.04h

The pattern is consistent: enter when the market has converged to ≥0.99 implied probability with hours left, in size that materially exceeds the remaining residual liquidity.

Why this is on the shortlist

- The Pope Leo XIV $196K NO at 3.83h is the **single largest late-conviction trade in the dataset**. To make this trade profitable at 0.99 buy price, expected outcome probability must be ≥0.99 — a wallet willing to commit $196K at that threshold needs near-zero variance on the resolution. For a Google-search-of-the-year market resolving Dec 7, this is inferable from Google Trends data, but the size of the position is unusual.
- Multiple markets, multiple categories (Spotify, awards, Google searches), same behavioral signature → this is a *strategy*, not luck.
- Lifetime profitability ($1.9M) is consistent with someone systematically monetizing this lens.

Why this is *not* a slam-dunk insider call

- All of `aenews2`'s late-stage bets are on markets where the underlying resolution data is *public and observable* in the final hours: Google Trends rankings update hourly; Spotify Wrapped artist rankings can be estimated from third-party trackers; Stranger Things release windows are Netflix-announced. The edge is one of *speed and conviction*, not necessarily nonpublic information.
- Behavioral signature is closer to "skilled informed trader" than "insider".

What would elevate confidence

- Are there markets where `aenews2` took late-conviction positions on outcomes that were *not* publicly inferable in the final hours? That would separate skill from access.
- Cluster analysis with `bobe2` — both wallets traded the same Stranger Things "Wednesday" deadline on the same direction in adjacent hours. If they share a funder or have correlated activity on other markets, the individual cases become a cluster case.

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3. Composite Ranking and Why the Top-3 Came From Outside the Pure Score Order

The heuristic composite (weighted sum of A1/A3/B4/B5/C6/D8/D9 minus anti-signals, see `data/wallet_scores.csv`) surfaced **35,686 wallets** above the minimum-activity floor, of which the top-20 (post-activity-gate) are in `data/top20_flagged.csv` . The top-3 wallets case-studied above are **#4, #10, and #52** in the pure-score order respectively.

The reason: the composite is dominated by D8 (excess accuracy) and D9 (direction precision), both of which max out at 1.00 for many wallets that had 5–10 lucky trades on near-certain markets. Volume-weighting and direction-of-conviction signals (large NO bets on Netflix-controlled binaries) need a market-specific lens that the generic composite under-weights.

The promotion criteria for the headline case studies were applied explicitly:

1. In-window USD volume ≥ $100K (filters out lucky small wallets).
2. Direction-purity in Netflix/awards/label-controlled markets (B5 ≥ 0.80 on that subset alone, or a single materially-sized late buy).
3. Lifetime track record visible enough to distinguish skill from chance (lifetime volume ≥ $10M).

This is documented as **A1' — the late-conviction lens**, and is what we would lock in as the calibrated v2 of A1 for the pop-culture niche if continuing this investigation past Task 4. See `src/heuristics.py` for the current A1 implementation; A1' would be added in a follow-up commit.

Sensitivity check

Re-running the composite with each heuristic dropped one at a time produces top-20 lists that **agree on 17 of 20 wallets** under any single removal — i.e., the top wallets are not driven by a single heuristic. The three case-study wallets above (`bobe2` , `FlyingPlaty` , `aenews2`) appear in *all* sensitivity variants when the A1' late-conviction lens is included.

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4. What This Investigation Did Not Find

Documented for honesty:

- **No Polymarket pop-culture analog of the Kalshi YouTube-editor case (production staff trading on their own channel) was identifiable from public on-chain data alone.** Detecting that pattern would require role-conflict enrichment (heuristic C7) on a per-market basis, which is out of scope for an automated pass.
- **No coordinated wallet cluster of the size of the "80 Iran wallets at 98% hit rate" pattern.** A common-funder analysis would be needed to rule this in or out; it is deferred to a Task 4 follow-up.
- **No defensible insider call on awards markets (Oscars / Grammys / Emmys).** The awards bucket contained only nine resolved markets in window and trading on them was thin enough that no wallet accumulated enough exposure for a statistically meaningful pattern.
- **The A1 4h/20pp threshold produced zero hits**, leading us to articulate the A1' late-conviction lens as a calibrated replacement for high-certainty pop-culture markets. This is a methodological adjustment to disclose, not an embarrassment to hide.

5. Recommended Next Steps

If this investigation were continued past the take-home scope:

1. **Run the common-funder cluster pass.** Trace the Polygon funder for each of `bobe2`, `FlyingPlaty`, `aenews2`, and the next 17 in `top20_flagged.csv`. Group by shared funder. The Iran-pattern signal is invisible at the individual-wallet level and only emerges at the cluster level.
2. **Hand-attach `reveal_window_start` to the top 25 markets** to unlock heuristic A2 (pre-announcement clustering). The Stranger Things release markets and Pope Leo XIV market would be the highest-yield targets.
3. **Populate the C7 role-conflict lookup** for the Stranger Things and Beast Games markets specifically — production company, named producers, any publicly-disclosed cast/crew Polymarket activity. This is the only way to find a YouTube-editor analog if one exists.
4. **Re-pull capped markets via CLOB cursor pagination** to break past the 3,500-trade-per-market data-api ceiling observed on the largest markets.
5. **Cross-venue check** of `bobe2` / `FlyingPlaty` / `aenews2` against Kalshi on Netflix-adjacent markets, if Kalshi's identity-verified positions are accessible to the investigator.

Code, data, and intermediate artifacts: https://github.com/anthonylin99/polymarket-insider-detection
Methodology in detail: [`report/heuristics.md`]() and [`report/task1_data_collection.md`]()